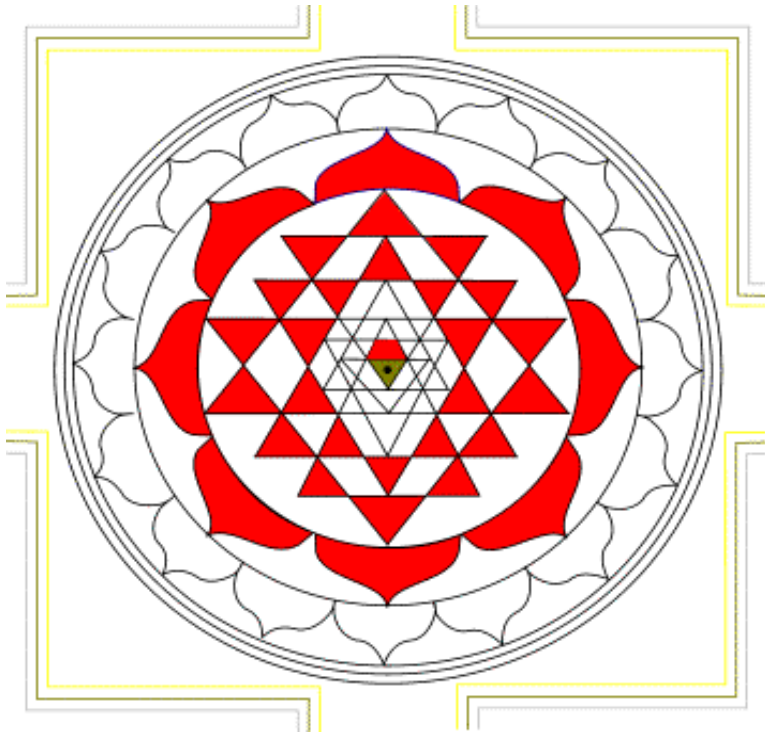




EDITOR IN CHIEF: SWAMI PARANAND TIRTH

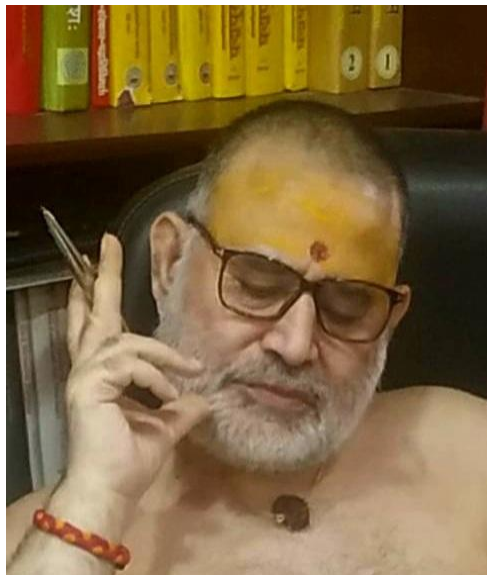
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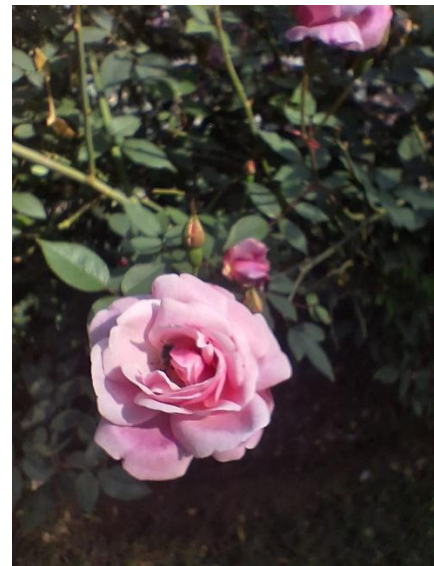
April-June 2026



From the chief editor's desk

Yugnadha -Mystery of the erotic semiotics

The spiritual nuptial as seen in mystic relics, canons and religious art has nothing carnal or banal in it. As one mystic canon says this is just an analogy to facilitate the common place phenomena of tantric



experience most of which happens in the subtle and para rational realm and needs to be explained to a novice in a befitting way .

उपाययमवताराय मूर्खस्तं मन्यते विधिम् ।

“only a dunce will misread such semiotics as an injunction”

Objective and subjective awareness merge into one another to generate a pure self evident consciousness, owing to their relative and interdependent nature the semiotics of their nuptial conjugal is to refute their successive transcendence. This is different from the vedantic jahad-ajahad Laksana (the logic of bilateral elimination of attributes to justify the innate unison) firstly because this is merely a rational specification to assert one's own essential nature and to refute other interpretations of the great dictum -mahavakyam , by the dualist schools of thought .secondly both objective as well as subjective portion of the phenomena are conditioned and superimposed and there is no notion of a third stream line of underlying consciousness that interlaces and outlasts their final dissolution.

The idea that wisdom and means are inseparable may not be appealing to a simpleton but the icon of prajna and upaya in nuptial embrace is. Agreeability and appeal have been as effective means of the propagation of faith as empathy and compassion. This holds good even for the assertion of some doctrine . The rising of the great union happens when both objective(इदंता) and subjective (अहंता)awareness dissolve into the eternal consciousness which is self evident and from an absolute perspective was never alloyed by both .

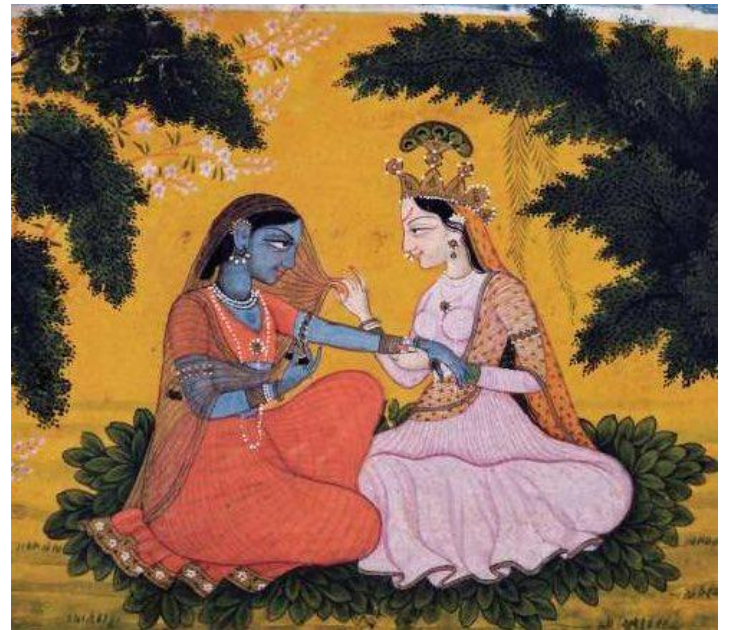
This mystic phenomena was abundantly used in the ideal vaishnaite cults where duality is the main propound. They explain the phenomena of महासामरस्यम् the great homogeneity in a somewhat similar fashion . Most of this is descriptive but there is no dearth of depiction also. Like two waves Krishna and Radha merge into a nuptial conjugal, Krishna becomes Radha and Radha becomes Krishna, this process of transpersonalization is repeated so rapidly that both lose their individual identities and merge into a homogenous mass of pure consolidate bliss. The bilateral decay of individuality is more rapid than the decay of a meson subatomic particle which happens in the billionth of a second . The cult says that up till now both Radha and Krishna could not “see one another” (लाल पिया में भईन चिन्हारी) Before they get to recognise one another they are transformed into another.

From a Shaiva agamic stand point This is just what happens when अहंता weds इदंता, both lose their

respective attributes, the seer becomes the seen and vice versa and this happens in a very incalculable time fraction so the conventional mode of successive transcendence is impractical if it has to happen it has to be concomitant and simultaneous.

Swami Paranand Tirth
Founder president & CEO
YTA yoga Tantra and Agama (inc.)

PDG
Yog Tantra et Agama centre (Montreal CAN)



“Lilahava, Krishna and Radha exchange clothes” Pahari, Kangra; 18th cent.
<https://x.com/museumchd/status/1139473642360721408/photo/1>

PC: Govt. Museum Chandigarh

Editorial



Man tu shudam, tu mun shudi (I have become you, and you me)

Man tun shudam, tu jaan shudi (I became the body, you the soul)

Taakas na guyad baad azeen (So that no one says hereafter)

Man deegaram, tu deegari (That I am someone else, and you another)

sings Amir Khusro to his master Nizamuddin Auliya and gives us a glimpse of losing oneself in one's beloved. In the same vein in Jayadeva's Gitagovinda Radha's intense longing and love for Krishna reaches a state of divine ecstasy where the boundaries of individual identity dissolve, leading her to experience herself as one with him. This profound spiritual union is often described as Radha becoming Krishna in her consciousness, embodying his very essence. The world of art and literature all over the world is filled with examples of divine longing and metaphorical visual representations of the ultimate union.

The most powerful and easily recognizable symbol of this unity is the union of the male and female seen in almost all ancient cultures. Before the world learned to scoff at sexuality and consider it immoral to explore its potentials it was seen as the most powerful way of expression that human beings had. In one of the passages in Mahabharat, sage Upamanyu says that human beings are not born with attributes of gods like conch, lotus, shell or mace but they are born with the symbols of Mahadeva and devi in the form of linga and yoni, hence they are to be worshipped.

Explaining the notion we begin with the insightful editorial by our Guru Maharaj, Swami Paranand Tirth ji on the concept of Yugnadha. "Objective and subjective awareness merge into one another to generate a pure self evident consciousness, owing to their relative and interdependent nature the semiotics of their nuptial conjugal is to refute their successive transcendence" writes Swamiji.

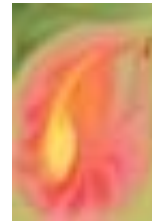
Following this we have an erudite article on 'Dakshinamurti Across Traditions: A Study Based on the Pashupata Sutra and Dakshinamurti Ashtakam' by Prof. Satheesha K. He opines that Dakshinamurti is not just a deity or symbolic form, but the expression of a profound truth: that the Guru, the knowledge, and the liberated state are all one and the same reality. Next we have a working paper by Geetika on 'An insight into the non material and non instrumental casual efficacy of Shiva according to Shivdrsti'. The paper owes its genesis to the YTA classes on Shivdrsti and has been written under the divine guidance of Swamiji. Śivadr̥ṣṭi is a highly significant and ancient philosophical text of the non-dual (Advaita) tradition of Kashmir Shaivism. This work lays the foundation of the *Pratyabhijñā* (Recognition) school of Kashmir Shaivism, which was further developed by philosophers like Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta.

This is followed by translation and exposition of the concluding verse from Ishwar Pratibhijna Karika from the YTA Study Circle and a brief insight into the online classes conducted by YTA.

In this issue we present a Photo Essay on the recent YTA Colloquium on Agama Shastra held on 9th April 2026 at Shri Lal Bahadur Shastri National Sanskrit University.

The issue ends with a light hearted and witty poem by Ambika Talwar titled 'Yellow Mustard Flower'.

In this poem she playfully talks about the importance of of tiny mustard seed while using it a metaphor for human quest.



Kimiya

Dakshinamurti Across Traditions: A Study Based on the Pashupata Sutra and Dakshinamurti Ashtakam



✍ Prof. Satheesha K.S.

Abstract

The study examines the idea of Dakshinamurti by comparing the Lakulisa-Pashupata system with the Advaita Vedanta of Adi Shankaracharya. It argues that the Pashupata tradition already contains the basic idea of Shiva as Guru, who grants liberation through teaching and grace. Shankara develops this further by presenting Dakshinamurti as pure consciousness itself, where teaching happens through silence rather than words. The paper ultimately shows that Dakshinamurti represents the highest philosophical development of the earlier Guru-Shiva concept, now expressed in a non-dual framework.

Introduction –

The Lakulisha Pashupata tradition holds a foundational place in the history of Shaivism, standing as one of its earliest organized sects with a deeply developed philosophical and ritual system. At the center of this tradition is Lakulisha, who is traditionally regarded as the 28th and final incarnation of Lord Shiva. According

to sacred accounts, his manifestation took place at Kayavarohan (present-day Karvan in Gujarat), a site of immense theological importance. The very name *Kayavarohan*, meaning “descent into the body,” reflects the doctrine of divine embodiment, where Shiva is believed to have entered a lifeless body to appear as Lakulisha. This sacred geography is preserved today in the Lakulish Temple Kayavarohan, which continues to be a central pilgrimage and doctrinal anchor for the tradition.

While traditional narratives often place Lakulisha in a much earlier, even mythic past, modern scholarship based on inscriptions and textual analysis generally situates him between 200 BCE and 200 CE¹, with many scholars favoring the 1st–2nd century CE. This dating is supported by important historical evidence such as the Mathura Pillar Inscription from the time of Chandragupta II in the 4th century CE, which refers to a lineage of Pashupata teachers. By tracing this lineage backward, scholars reasonably infer that Lakulisha and his immediate disciples must have lived around the 2nd century CE. Furthermore, the doctrinal ideas found in the Pashupata system show connections with early devotional currents like the Bhagavata and Pancharatra traditions, placing it within a broader phase of religious system-building in early Indian history.

The Pashupata Sutra, the central text of this tradition, later elaborated by Kaundinya in his Pancarthabhashya, presents a highly structured philosophical system. It is organized around five key principles: **karya** (the dependent world and the bound soul), **karana** (Shiva as the ultimate cause), **yoga** (the process of union with the divine), **vidhi** (prescribed practices and discipline), and **duhkha-anta** (the complete cessation of suffering). This framework² reveals a mature theological vision in which liberation is not merely the cessation of pain, but an elevation into a state resembling Shiva characterized by higher knowledge and spiritual power.

¹ For understanding the historical period of Lakulisa and the Pashupata tradition, one of the key sources is the Mathura Pillar Inscription, which offers early inscriptional evidence of this lineage. Modern scholars have studied this alongside textual traditions to estimate his date. Notably, R. G. Bhandarkar in *Vaishnavism, Saivism and Minor Religious Systems* (1913) and D. R. Bhandarkar in his writings on Lakulisa in the *Archaeological Survey*

Reports suggest that he likely lived in the early centuries of the Common Era.

² For the philosophical understanding of the Pashupata tradition, the Pashupata Sutra along with the commentary of Kaundinya (Pancarthabhashya) explains the fivefold doctrine in a structured way. Modern scholars like Gavin Flood and Alexis Sanderson further discuss and analyze these ideas within early Shaiva traditions.

as Lakulisha's staff signifies inner discipline and the transmission of knowledge, Dandapani Bhairava's danda represents authority and the maintenance of cosmic and social order, particularly in sacred spaces such as Kashi. Thus, while Lakulisha embodies **inner mastery**, Bhairava represents **external regulation**, and together they express complementary dimensions of Shaiva thought.

This connection extends further into the domain of asceticism and spiritual discipline. Lakulisha is closely associated with yogic restraint and the transformation of inner energy into spiritual realization. Similarly, Bhairava-oriented traditions, particularly those linked with ascetic groups like the Kapalikas, emphasize rigorous practices aimed at dissolving ego and transcending conventional limitations. Both streams reflect a deeper Shaiva ideal: the harnessing of austerity and inner strength as means to overcome bondage and attain higher consciousness.



Within this system, Lakulisha is not only revered as a divine incarnation but also as a **Jagadguru**, a great teacher who systematized the path of ascetic discipline. His iconography especially the **lakuta (staff)** that he carries holds deep symbolic meaning, representing authority, restraint, and spiritual control. A parallel symbolism can be observed in **Dandapani Bhairava**, another important form within the Shaiva tradition. Just





[Lakulish Temple Kayavarohan - Kayavarohan (also known as Karvan), in Gujarat]

From both historical and philosophical perspectives, the Lakulisha–Pashupata system represents a crucial turning point in the evolution of Shaivism. Emerging from sacred centers like Kayavarohan and grounded in both divine incarnation and systematic teaching, it stands as one of the earliest fully developed Shaiva traditions. Its integration of theology, ritual practice, ascetic discipline, and psychological insight not only

shaped later Shaiva schools but also contributed significantly to the broader trajectory of Indian religious and philosophical thought.

Dakshinamurti within the Lakulisa-Shankara Continuum -

Dakshinamurti holds a very special place in Indian philosophy as the ideal Guru the one who is both the source of knowledge and the means through which it is transmitted. While Adi Shankaracharya clearly describes this form in the Dakshinamurti Ashtakam, a closer look at the Lakulisa-Pashupata tradition shows that this idea did not suddenly appear with him. Its foundations were already present in earlier texts like the Pashupata Sutra and the Kaundinya Bhashya. In the Pashupata system, Shiva is not just a distant cosmic principle but a living guide. He is both the cause of the universe and the teacher who leads the seeker toward liberation. The Kaundinya Bhashya clearly states that scriptural teachings only make sense within the relationship between teacher and disciple. This is a crucial point it shows that liberation is not merely a philosophical idea, but a guided process in which Shiva himself plays the role of Guru³.

Another important aspect of this system is the role of divine grace. Liberation is not achieved by effort alone. Even though the aspirant follows discipline and practice, the final step depends on the grace of Shiva (Ishvara-prasada). This means that Shiva is not just a teacher, but also the one who makes liberation possible. Because of this, the system naturally requires a way for Shiva to reveal knowledge to the seeker. This is where the idea of Dakshinamurti begins to emerge. Although not fully developed in name and form, the essential idea is already there Shiva as the revealer of knowledge.

In contrast, Advaita Vedanta, especially as presented in the Dakshinamurti Ashtakam, takes this idea to a deeper level. Here, the Guru is no longer just an external teacher but pure consciousness itself. Teaching happens

³ For the idea of Shiva as Guru in the Pashupata tradition, see the Pshupata Sutra along with Kaundinya's [Pancarthatbhashya](#), where

the role of divine guidance and the teacher disciple relationship is clearly explained.

through silence (mauna), where truth is directly realized rather than explained⁴.

This leads to the central question of the study: how does the Pashupata idea of Shiva as Guru lead to Shankara's concept of Dakshinamurti? And how does this idea evolve from a theistic teaching model into a fully non-dual philosophical vision? To answer this, we must trace the continuity between the two systems and understand how Dakshinamurti becomes the meeting point of theology, teaching, and ultimate reality.

Shiva as Acharya in Lakulisa Pashupata Darshana

In the Lakulisa Pashupata system, Shiva is not simply described as a distant cause of the universe. He is actively involved as a teacher an acharya who guides the seeker toward liberation. The Kaundinya Bhashya makes this very clear by stating that all teachings depend on the relationship between teacher and disciple. This means that knowledge is not accidental; it is built into the very structure of the system⁵. Here, Shiva plays two roles at once. He is the ultimate reality (ontological ground), and at the same time, he is the one who reveals knowledge (epistemic guide). He leads the aspirant from ignorance to liberation.

This becomes necessary because of the basic distinction in the system between Pashu (the bound individual) and Pashupati (the Lord). The individual, being dependent and limited, cannot achieve liberation on their own. They require guidance. Shiva, being independent and all-knowing, becomes that guide.

Another key idea here is divine grace. The texts clearly state that liberation does not happen just because of effort. Even practices like yoga and discipline only

prepare the aspirant. The final transformation from bondage to liberation happens through Shiva's grace⁶. In this sense, knowledge itself is a form of grace.

From an epistemological point of view, this means that knowledge is not self-produced. It is revealed. The seeker comes to know reality only through proper instruction and guidance.

Even though the texts do not directly describe Dakshinamurti in iconographic form, all the essential elements are already present: Shiva as teacher, knowledge as the means of liberation, and grace as the enabling force. Together, these form an early version of the Dakshinamurti idea.

Thus, the Lakulisa Pashupata system creates a strong foundation where Shiva is simultaneously the cause, the controller, and the teacher. This prepares the ground for the next stage, where this idea is further developed in Advaita Vedanta.



“Mahadevasya Dakshinamurteh” - Emergence of Guru-Shiva -

The phrase “Mahadevasya Dakshinamurteh” in the Pashupata Sutra marks an important turning point. It is here that the idea of Shiva as Guru begins to take a clearer philosophical shape.

“महादेवस्य दक्षिणामूर्तेः”⁷

⁴ For the Advaita understanding of Dakshinamurti as the silent Guru, see Adi Shankaracharya's **Dakshinamurti Ashtakam**, which presents the Guru as pure consciousness and emphasizes knowledge through silence (mauna).

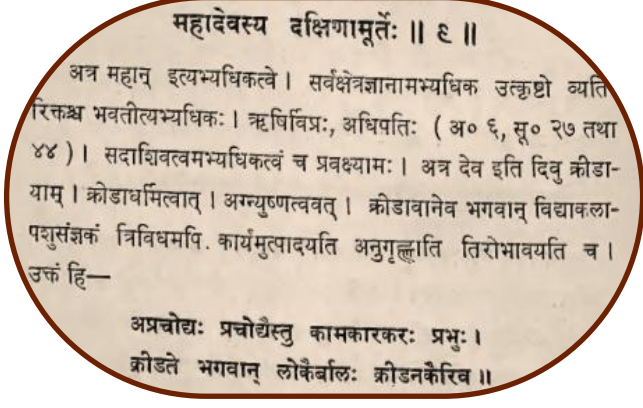
⁵ For the role of Shiva as teacher (acharya) and revealer of knowledge in the Pashupata system, see the Pāśupata Sutra along with Kaundinya's **Pancarhabhashya**, which emphasizes the teacher-disciple relationship and divine guidance.

⁶ On the concepts of Pashu, Pashupati, and the role of divine grace (Ishvara-prasada) in liberation, see Gavin Flood, **An Introduction to Hinduism** (1996), and Alexis Sanderson's studies on early Shaiva traditions and ascetic theology.

⁷ महादेवस्य दक्षिणामूर्तेः॥ पाशुपतसूत्रम् - ६॥

अत्र महान् इत्यभ्यधिकत्वे।
सर्वक्षेत्रज्ञानामभ्यधिकः उत्कृष्टो व्यतिरिक्तश्च भवतीति
अभ्यधिकः। ऋषिविप्रः, अधिपतिः।
सदाशिवत्वमभ्यधिकत्वं च प्रवक्ष्यामः। अत्र देव इति दिवु
क्रीडायाम्। क्रीडामित्वात्। अग्न्युष्णत्ववत्। क्रीडावानेव

Although the sutra does not describe Dakshinamurti in a visual or symbolic way, its deeper meaning suggests that Shiva is not just the cause of the universe, but also the one who reveals knowledge. The word “Dakshina” here is not just about direction it implies a certain orientation toward teaching, as if Shiva is turned toward the seeker to guide them.



This interpretation is supported by the emphasis on instruction in the Kaundinya Bhashya. The seeker’s progress depends on receiving proper teaching, and this teaching only has meaning within the teacher-disciple relationship. So when the sutra refers to Shiva in this way, it is pointing toward his role as a teacher. Philosophically, this is a shift. Shiva is no longer only a

distant, transcendent cause he becomes directly involved in the process of liberation by revealing knowledge. This bridges the gap between abstract philosophy and practical spiritual life.

It also has an important epistemological meaning. Knowledge is not something that the seeker simply discovers alone. It is something that is received through discipline, proximity to the teacher, and ultimately through grace.

In this sense, Dakshinamurti is not a new concept added later, but a natural development of the idea already present in the Pashupata system. It represents the point where teaching, grace, and realization come together.

The Deeper Meaning of “Dakshinamurti” (Conceptual Bridge)

In the spiritual and philosophical traditions of India, names are never arbitrary. They are carefully chosen expressions that encode layers of metaphysical insight. The name “Dakshinamurti”, associated with Lord Shiva as the primordial teacher, is a profound example of this principle. At first glance, the term appears simple, but upon deeper examination, it reveals

भगवान् विद्याकलापशुसंज्ञकं त्रिविधमपि ।
कार्यमुत्पादयति अनुगृह्णाति तिरोभावयति च ।
उक्तं हि

अप्रचोद्यः प्रचोद्यैस्तु कामकारकरः प्रभुः ।

क्रीडते भगवान् लोकैर्बालः क्रीडनकैरिव ॥

देवस्य इति षष्ठी । स्वस्वामिभावः सम्बन्धः । परिग्रहार्थमेवाधिकुरुते । अत्र दक्षिणेति दिप्रतिविभागे भवति । आदित्यो दिशो विभजति । दिशश्च मूर्ति विभजन्ति । मूर्तिर्नाम यदेतद् देवस्य दक्षिणे पार्श्वे स्थितेनोदङ्मुखेनोपान्ते यद् रूपमुपलभ्यते वृषध्वजशूलपाणिनन्दिमहाकालोलिङ्गादिलक्षणं, यद्वा लौकिकाः प्रतिपद्यन्ते महादेवस्यायतनमिति तत्रोपस्थेयम् । दक्षिणामूर्तिग्रहणात् पूर्वोत्तरपश्चिमानां मूर्तीनां प्रतिषेधः । मूर्तिनियोगाच्च मूर्त्यभावे नियमलोपः ।

भैक्ष्यानुपयोगान्निर्घातानामुक्तत्वाच्चेत्यर्थः ।

विधिरित्युपदिष्टानाम् अर्थानां भस्मस्नानोपदेशादप्सु स्नानादीनां प्रतिषेधः । भस्मशयनोपदेशाद्

विषयशयनादीनां प्रतिषेधः । आयतने

वसत्यर्थोपदेशाच्छेषवसत्यर्थप्रतिषेधः ।

हसिताद्युपदेशाच्छेषोपहारप्रतिषेधः । निर्माल्योपदेशात्

प्रत्याग्राणां माल्यानां प्रतिषेधः ।

भस्मनिर्माल्यलिङ्गोपदेशाच्छेषलिङ्गप्रतिषेधः ।

महादेवग्रहणादन्य-देवताभक्तिप्रतिषेधः ।

दक्षिणाभूतिग्रहणात् पूर्वपश्चिमानां मूर्तीनां प्रतिषेधः ।

एवम् अस्य ब्राह्मणस्य पूर्वप्रसिद्धा नियमा नियमैः

प्रतिषिध्यन्ते । कीलकप्रतिकीलकवत्

पुराणोदकनवोदकवच्चेति ॥

a rich spectrum of meanings that bridge language, symbolism, and Vedantic philosophy.

At the most basic level, the word Dakshinamurti is often interpreted as “the one who faces the south direction.” In temple iconography, Dakshinamurti is indeed depicted as seated facing south, unlike most deities who face east or north. However, this literal meaning is only the outer layer.

A deeper interpretation comes from the Sanskrit root “daksha”, meaning capable, skillful, or competent. From this standpoint, Dakshinamurti is the supremely competent principle that governs creation, sustenance, and dissolution through perfect knowledge. This connects the idea of power with wisdom showing that true authority arises from knowledge.

Another important meaning of “Dakshina” is related to intellect (buddhi). Here, it refers not to ordinary thinking, but to a refined and purified intellect capable of distinguishing between the real (sat) and the unreal (asat)⁸. From this perspective, Dakshinamurti is that supreme reality which shines through a purified mind. This shifts the understanding from an external deity to an inner principle of consciousness.

This naturally leads to the idea of Dakshinamurti as the inner Guru. He is not only an external teacher who imparts knowledge, but also the inner presence that reveals truth within the seeker⁹. Through practices such as listening, reflection, and meditation, the aspirant becomes capable of recognizing this inner illumination. The name also carries a soteriological meaning. Samsara is often compared to an ocean of suffering and ignorance. Dakshinamurti is the one who helps the seeker cross this ocean by providing the knowledge necessary for liberation. In this sense, he is both the teacher and the liberator.

When all these meanings are brought together, Dakshinamurti becomes a complete philosophical concept: the south-facing form, the embodiment of

supreme knowledge, the ideal teacher, the illuminating consciousness within, and the guide to liberation.

Placed after the Pashupata Sutra phrase “Mahadevasya Dakshinamurteh,” this deeper analysis clarifies that the term is not merely descriptive it encodes the full transition from Shiva as teacher to Shiva as the very principle of knowledge itself. This prepares the ground for its highest expression in Advaita Vedanta.

मौनव्याख्या प्रकटित परब्रह्मतत्त्वं युवानं वर्षिष्ठान्तेवसदृषिगणैरावृतं ब्रह्मनिष्ठैः।
आचार्येन्द्रं करकलित चिन्मुद्रामानन्दमूर्तिं स्वात्मारामं मुदितवदनं
दक्षिणामूर्तिमीडे॥

Dakshinamurti: From Instruction to Silent Revelation

With Adi Shankaracharya, the idea of Dakshinamurti reaches its most refined philosophical expression. In his Dakshinamurti Ashtakam, the Guru is no longer simply a teacher who explains truth through words. Instead, he is pure consciousness itself, and his teaching happens through silence what is called *mauna-vyakhyana*.¹⁰



This marks a major shift from the Lakulisa Pashupata system. There, Shiva functions as a teacher within a clear relationship between Guru and disciple. But in Advaita, this distinction begins to dissolve. The Guru is not separate from the seeker; rather, the Guru represents the very Self.

⁸ On the symbolic and philosophical meanings of terms like “Dakshina” (as intellect, skill, and inner illumination) in Vedantic thought, see Gavin Flood, *An Introduction to Hinduism* (1996), and Alexis Sanderson’s studies on Shaiva symbolism and theology.

⁹ For the Advaita understanding of Dakshinamurti as the supreme Guru and inner consciousness, see Adi

Shankaracharya’s *Dakshinamurti Ashtakam*, which explains knowledge as arising through direct realization rather than external instruction.

¹⁰ Adi Shankaracharya’s *Dakshinamurti Ashtakam* (verses 1-4), which presents Dakshinamurti as the silent Guru, where knowledge is revealed through the removal of ignorance.

The Ashtakam makes this clear by showing that truth is not something communicated through language. Instead, it is directly realized within. The role of the Guru is not to give new knowledge, but to remove ignorance. Once ignorance is gone, knowledge naturally shines forth. This aligns with a central idea in Advaita that knowledge is not created but revealed. It is always present, but hidden. The Guru's role is simply to uncover it.

Another important development here is the reinterpretation of the Guru-Shiva relationship. In the Pashupata system, there is a real difference between the individual (Pashu) and the Lord (Pashupati). Shankara internalizes this relationship. The Guru is no longer outside the Guru is the Self itself, appearing in a teaching form.

Even the symbolic features of Dakshinamurti, like the chinmudra or his silent presence under the banyan tree, point toward this truth that the individual self and ultimate reality are one.

From the perspective of knowledge, this represents a shift from indirect understanding (through instruction) to direct realization (through experience). In the earlier system, knowledge is given. In Advaita, it is recognized. Thus, Shankara does not reject the earlier tradition he completes it. What was once a teaching relationship becomes a realization of identity.

Comparative Analysis: Lakulisa Guru-Shiva and Shankara's Dakshinamurti

When we compare the Lakulisa Pashupata system with Shankara's Advaita, we see both continuity and transformation.

In the Pashupata system, Shiva is an external Guru who teaches the seeker through instruction and grants liberation through grace. The entire system is built on the relationship between teacher and disciple. Knowledge is something that is given, and liberation is something that is achieved with the help of Shiva.¹¹

In contrast, Shankara transforms this idea. He internalizes the Guru and presents Dakshinamurti as the Self itself. The distinction between teacher and student disappears. What remains is pure consciousness revealing itself.

This difference is especially clear in how knowledge is understood. In the earlier system, knowledge is acquired through effort, discipline, and grace. The seeker gradually becomes ready to receive it. But in Advaita, knowledge is always present. It is not created or transferred it is simply uncovered by removing ignorance.

The same shift happens with the idea of grace. In the Pashupata system, grace is something Shiva gives. In Advaita, grace is not an external act it is the very nature of consciousness. When ignorance is removed, grace is already there.

There is also a difference in how reality itself is understood. The Pashupata system maintains a real distinction between the individual and the Lord. Even in liberation, this difference remains. But in Advaita, this distinction is ultimately seen as unreal. Dakshinamurti represents the truth that the individual self and Brahman are one.

Despite all these differences, there is a strong continuity. Shankara does not discard the earlier ideas he builds on them. The importance of the Guru, knowledge, and grace remains, but their meaning is deepened and internalized.

Thus, the Lakulisa system can be seen as the foundation, and Dakshinamurti as its philosophical completion.

Philosophical Synthesis: Ontology, Epistemology, and Soteriology

When we look more deeply, Dakshinamurti brings together three major philosophical dimensions: the nature of reality (ontology), the nature of knowledge

¹¹ The Pashupata view of Shiva as an external Guru who grants knowledge and liberation through grace, from Pāśupata Sutra with Kaundinya's [Pancarthatbhashya](#).

(epistemology), and the nature of liberation (soteriology).

In the Pashupata system, reality is understood in a dualistic way. There is a clear difference between Pashu (the individual soul) and Pashupati (the Lord). Shiva is independent, all-knowing, and the cause of everything, while the individual is dependent and bound. Liberation happens when the individual approaches Shiva through discipline and receives his grace¹².

In Advaita, this understanding changes completely. The distinction between individual and Lord is no longer seen as ultimately real. It is considered a result of ignorance. Dakshinamurti represents pure consciousness the underlying reality¹³ in which both subject and object appear.

From the perspective of knowledge, the Pashupata system emphasizes instruction. Knowledge comes through teaching, guided by the Guru. But Advaita shifts this to self-revelation. Knowledge is self-luminous it does not need to be produced. It only needs to be uncovered. This is why silence becomes the highest form of teaching.

When it comes to liberation, both systems agree that it is the ultimate goal, but they understand it differently. In the Pashupata system, liberation is something achieved it is freedom from suffering and dependence, granted through grace. In Advaita, liberation is not something new that happens. It is simply the recognition of one's true nature as non-dual consciousness.

So, what changes is not the goal, but the understanding of it from attainment to recognition.

In this way, Dakshinamurti becomes the bridge between the two systems. The Pashupata tradition provides the structure Guru, discipline, grace while Advaita transforms these into a deeper, non-dual realization.

Mauna, Guru-Tattva, and Reinterpretation -

The final stage of this philosophical development is best expressed through the idea of *mauna* silence.

In the Pashupata system, Shiva teaches through instruction. There is a clear process of learning, involving words, practices, and guidance¹⁴. But this still assumes a difference between teacher and student.

Shankara goes beyond this by presenting Dakshinamurti as the Guru who teaches through silence. This silence does not mean the absence of teaching. Instead, it represents the highest form of teaching one that goes beyond words.

Truth, in its deepest sense, cannot be fully expressed through language. It must be directly realized. Silence points to this direct realization. In this understanding, the Guru is no longer an external authority. The Guru becomes an inner presence the light of consciousness itself. Teaching is no longer a transfer of knowledge, but a removal of ignorance.

This also changes how we understand the phrase “Mahadevasya Dakshinamurteh.” In the Pashupata system, it refers to Shiva as the teacher who guides the seeker. In Advaita, it points to the inner Self the ever-present consciousness that reveals itself without any external mediation.

Conclusion -

From this entire discussion, it becomes clear that Dakshinamurti is not a completely new or isolated idea, but rather the natural culmination of the Lakulisa-Pashupata tradition. The earlier system already establishes Shiva as Guru, emphasizing discipline, grace, and the centrality of knowledge. It provides a structured path for spiritual progress, which later finds a deeper philosophical expression in Advaita.

According to some traditional and sectarian accounts, Adi Shankaracharya is placed much earlier than the commonly accepted 8th century CE sometimes even around 500 BCE or earlier. Within such alternative chronologies, he is brought closer in time to Lakulisha, and certain narratives even describe them as contemporaries who engaged in philosophical debate

¹² Pashupata Sutra; Kaundinya, [Pancarthatbhashya](#).

¹³ Adi Shankaracharya, [Dakshinamurti Ashtakam](#) (verses 1–4).

¹⁴ Pashupata Sutra; Kaundinya, [Pancarthatbhashya](#).

(vada), with Shankaracharya emerging victorious. Some of these traditions further claim that this debate is recorded in a Tamrashasana attributed to King Toramana, though such accounts remain part of later sectarian or oral traditions rather than firmly established historical evidence.

At a deeper theological level, both Lakulisha and Shankaracharya are regarded in many traditions as incarnations of Shiva himself. From this perspective, their teachings are not seen as opposing, but as complementary expressions of Shaiva wisdom unfolding across time. The Lakulisa system lays the foundational structure of discipline, devotion, and Guru-centered practice, while Shankaracharya refines and internalizes these ideas into a non-dual philosophical vision. In this way, Shaivism as a whole is enriched and benefited through the contributions of both.

Conceptually, this continuity becomes especially clear in the development of the idea of Dakshinamurti. What appears in the Pashupata system as Shiva the teacher gradually evolves in Advaita into Shiva as pure consciousness, the silent revealer of truth. Shankaracharya does not reject earlier Shaiva tattvas; rather, he absorbs and elevates them into a more subtle metaphysical framework. His elaboration of Dakshinamurti as the embodiment of Atma-jnana (self-knowledge) represents this culmination.

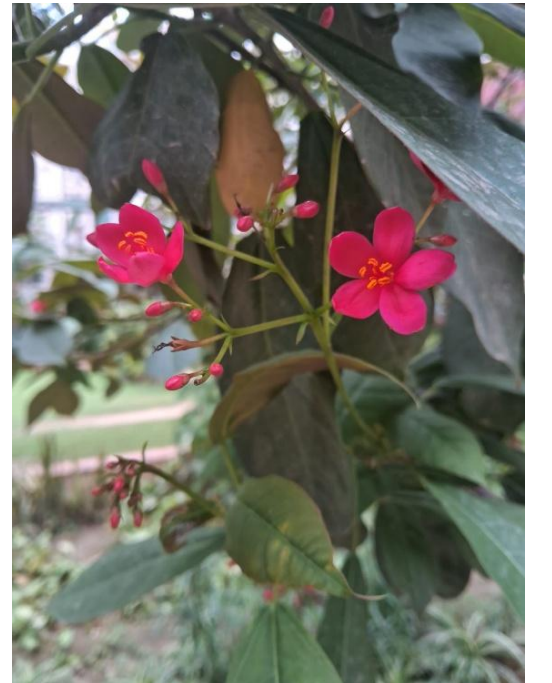
Building upon this foundation, the concept of the Guru undergoes a profound transformation. The Guru is no longer understood merely as an external instructor, but as the very principle of consciousness itself. Knowledge is no longer something transmitted from outside, but something that is self-revealed through the removal of ignorance. Likewise, liberation is not an attainment, but a recognition of one's true nature.

In this way, Dakshinamurti represents the highest point of this philosophical development, bringing together theology, epistemology, and soteriology into a unified vision. Ultimately, Dakshinamurti is not just a deity or symbolic form, but the expression of a profound truth: that the Guru, the knowledge, and the liberated state are all one and the same reality.

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(Dr. Satheesha K.S. is a Professor and currently serves as the **Head of the Department of Advaita Vedanta** at the **National Sanskrit University (NSU)** in Tirupati.)



An insight into the non material and non instrumental casual efficacy of Shiva according to Shivdrsti

Geetika Kaw Kher

मंगलाचरण

चिदाकाशमये स्वाङ्गे विश्वलेखाविधायिने।

सर्वभूतोद्भवभुवे नमो विषमचक्षुषे॥

“Beyond the gross space (sthula akasa), the subtle space (Sukshma akasa), and the mental space (cittakasa) that which is the space of pure consciousness (cidakasa) is itself the formless (partless) nature of Śiva. In this, the Supreme Lord, united with His power (sakti), brings forth the manifold diversity of the universe. The Supreme Lord alone is the ground upon which all wondrous phenomena take place.”

Salutation to Śiva as the “Viṣama-cakṣu” (the three-eyed one) is, in reality, nothing but *samāveśa* (a state of non-dual absorption), otherwise, in the attitude of the worshipper and the worshipped (the one who bows and the one to whom the bow is made), a hierarchy of higher and lower inevitably does not arise.” Therefore, the term “Viṣama-cakṣu” is explained by Utpaladeva in the following way: the two eyes represent *pramiti* (knowledge) and *prameya* (the object of knowledge), which manifest the apparent diversity of the universe. Although these seem distinct at first glance, the third eye, as the *pramātr* (the knower), is the self-luminous Self. It is free from the taint of duality and abides in its own self-revealing nature.

Introduction to the text:

Sivadrsti, is the first philosophical treatise on the monistic Saivism of Kashmir, authored by Acarya Somanandanath somewhere between 900-950 CE. The text is divided into seven chapters mainly aimed at analysing and refuting earlier theories and establishing a theory of non-differentiation—unity of subject and object, everything being of the nature of consciousness, *cid-rupa* and hence *Sivamaya*.

Somananda claims descent from the sage Durvasa and was the follower of Trayambaka school. An important commentary on this text, called *Śivadrṣṭi Vṛtti*, was written by his disciple Utpaladeva. This commentary

plays a crucial role in explaining the original text and clarifying its philosophical ideas.

Śivadrṣṭi is a highly significant and ancient philosophical text of the non-dual (Advaita) tradition of Kashmir Shaivism. This work lays the foundation of the *Pratyabhijñā* (Recognition) school of Kashmir Shaivism, which was further developed by philosophers like Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta.

The text is divided into seven chapters, in which various ancient philosophical systems—such as Buddhism, and Nyāya—are critically examined and refuted. The primary aim of Somananda is to establish the principle of non-duality (*abheda*), according to which there is no real distinction between the subject and the object. According to him, the entire universe is of the nature of consciousness (*cit*), which is none other than Śiva. Thus, the whole cosmos is permeated by Śiva-consciousness. Thus, Śivadrṣṭi is not merely a polemical text (engaged in refutation), but also a constructive philosophical work that establishes the non-dual doctrine of Kashmir Shaivism and views the entire universe as one unified consciousness.

Chapter-wise Overview:

The first chapter presents a brief summary of Somanandanatha's religious and philosophical views and perspectives. The second and third chapter discuss and refute the theories of grammarians, Shaktas and dualistic Saiva schools of thought. The fourth and the core chapter of the text establishes the main philosophical doctrine, the Siddhanta. Following fifth and sixth chapters too discuss the theories of purvapaksha in detail and finally in seventh chapter he explains the profound mystery that forms the basis of divine (visionary) power and ultimately leads the seeker to supreme bliss or liberation (*mokṣa*).

Brief Discussion of Causality in Other Philosophical Systems and its Refutation According to Śivadrṣṭi

Somananda analyses the ideas about causal efficacy propounded by Buddhist Epistemologists, Grammarians, Sankhkyas, Nyaya Vaisheka and Mimamsa schools and one by one, in a logical sequence he points at their limitations and posits the necessity of having an all possessing and unitary entity like Siva to justify the harmony and underlined logic that runs this universe and its functions. Somananda says that all things, although capable of producing

their own effects, are dependent for their efficacy on the one who deploys them toward some end, like a king who directs those who serve him.

In Pramana Vartika, Acarya Dharmakirti divides the objects of cognition into objects which are capable of causal efficacy (arthakriya) and those what are not real objects and may be termed as momentary apparations. He further divides them into ultimately real and conventionally real which is refuted by Somananda on the basis that what ever comes in the consciousness is already manifested and is ultimately real even if it no longer exists in a form grasped by our senses.

4.71 ekatattvam. vinaitac ca vyavaharo na jayate

'sabdarthayor na sam. bandho bhinnayor bhinnade'sayoh.

4.72. viruddharupayor bhinnakaran. agrahyayor api

mukhe hi 'sabdo bhumau ca vidyate 'rthah. kva sam. Gamah

Human discourse (vyavhara) opines Sivadrsti could not be produced in the absence of this single reality: there could be no connection of speech and object, which are (mutually) distinct, situated in different places, of (mutually) contradictory forms, and apprehended by different instruments. For the word is found in the mouth and the object (denoted by it) on the ground—where can there be a meeting (of the two)

savikalpasya yogitv̄ad yath̄avastu grahah. katham

4.84. tena jñeyam ekam eva vastu bhinne grahah. kutah.

If perception and conceptual thought were completely separate from each other, then it would be impossible for a concept to correctly grasp a particular object (svalakṣaṇa). A concept can only function if it is somehow connected to what is perceived; otherwise, accurate knowledge would not arise at all. Therefore, reality must be understood as fundamentally unified, not divided into disconnected parts.

Further, Somananda argues against the Buddhist epistemology that their denial of real universals (sāmānya) creates serious problems for inference. If there are no real, non-constructed universals underlying things, then it becomes impossible to explain how inference works.

For example, when we see smoke and infer fire, this process depends on some stable connection or unity between smoke and fire. But if everything is only a completely unique and momentary particular (svalakṣaṇa), with no real common basis, then such an association cannot be justified. The Buddhist position, therefore, cannot adequately explain how one particular instance can reliably lead to knowledge of another (e.g., that of smoke) with another (e.g., that of fire)

Critique of the Sankhya Theory:

The Satkaryavada or doctrine that the effect is existent in its cause prior to the production of the former is a Sankhya concept but the same cannot be justified unless one accepts Siva as both the cause and effect, the one entity responsible for keeping everything in its place suggests Somanandnatha,

ankuro jayata iti na bhavet karakatmata

4.46. asattve karakanam hi samuho na bhavet tada

karmakhyasya hyasatyatvat tatsam. bandho 'sata katham

4.47. tasmāt sa eva bhagavan svayam eva prakalpate

tath̄atath̄abh̄avar̄upaiḥ. sann eva parame'svarah.

When a sprout comes into being, it cannot play any role in causing its own production, because before it arises, it simply does not exist. Likewise, the various factors involved in producing something cannot operate at that stage, since the object they are supposed to act upon—the sprout—is not yet present. It is difficult to explain how these factors could relate to something that does not exist at all. Therefore, it must be accepted that it is only the Supreme Lord, **Parameśvara**, who truly exists in fullness and independently manifests Himself as the diverse forms of all entities, entirely through His own free will.

Nyaya Vaisesika:

According to their theory of cognition, knowledge occurs in two stages. First, a material sense organ (indriya) comes into contact (sannikarṣa) with an external object (artha), producing an initial perception. In the second stage, this information is transmitted to the knower, the self (ātman), through the mind (manas), which acts as an intermediary. However,

Somananda argues that such a complicated process fails to explain a simple experience like waking from sleep. If the self is completely unaware of a sound while asleep, then it cannot instruct the mind to convey that sound to it. On the other hand, if the self is already aware enough of the sound to direct the mind, then it is effectively not asleep at all, since this awareness would be no different from the waking state.

sabdader grahanam. nasti purvaparasahoditaih.

4.65. manasah. preranam. kasmāt pragjñānena vīna sthita

sarvaikatata evatra tatha sausuptabodhanam

4.66. ghatate katham. nimittasya pragyogayogacoditaih.

yoge jagradavasthaiva tasmāt sarvam. 'sivatmakam

If consciousness and its objects were completely separate, then sensory qualities like sound could not be known—whether cognition occurred in sequence or all at once. In the absence of an initial awareness, there would be no reason for the mind to begin functioning at all. For this reason, there must be an underlying unity in all experience.

Somananda further argues that the explanations given about awakening from deep sleep are flawed. If the cause of awakening (such as a sound) is already connected to the person before waking, then that state would already be similar to being awake. But if there is no such connection, then awakening could not occur at all. Therefore, the only consistent conclusion is that everything is fundamentally unified and is of the nature of Śiva.

Postion of Grammarians

According to the grammatical tradition, *word* (*vāk*) itself is the ultimate reality. Bhartrhari maintains that *spṛṣṭa* is the eternal principle through which meaning is revealed. The entire universe is understood as a manifestation of *śabda-brahman* (the Absolute as word), and both knowledge and objects are said to be grounded in language.

However, Somananda critiques this view and presents several arguments. He contends that language (word) cannot be an independent or ultimate reality. Words depend upon consciousness and are not self-luminous.

According to him, the grammarians' theory fails to adequately recognize the divine will (*icchā-śakti*) and the blissful freedom (*svātantrya*) of the Absolute. In *Śivadr̥ṣṭi*, it is not grammar as a discipline that is rejected, but rather the tendency to absolutize grammar—to treat language as the highest principle. Thus, the critique is directed not at grammar itself, but at the philosophical insistence that word alone is ultimate reality. For Somananda, it is not language but the free, conscious, and blissful nature of Śiva that constitutes the highest truth.

All other such doctrines are criticized on the grounds that they rely on dry logical argumentation and intellectual display, rather than leading to the direct experience of the deeper, consciousness-filled, Śiva-pervaded reality and hence miss the miracle that this creation is.

Bhava (Śiva) contemplates or manifests Himself in the form of the universe itself.

The mundane activity (*vyavhara*) exists only to the extent that the self is delighted according to Somananda. He explains the concept of *Sahanavasthiti* and gives the example of some magical rituals where a person visualizes himself as *garuda* and with proper incantation actually acquires the power to cure snake bite. This is further elaborated in the concept of 'Sarva Sivata Satta'. He further explains that if a golden crown is converted into a bracelet, the gold in it does not get affected, similarly by merely changing the form *Sivatva* does not change. It pervades all *padarthas* from *Prithvi* to *Sakti* and everything is *Sivamaya*. What one may see as destruction is nothing but incapacity of our senses to cognize the form.

Matter tends to remain constant, its states may change and sometimes may even disappear to our naked eyes but they do actually stay in a dormant or non-manifested form. The idea that multiplicity can only exist by way of unity beautifully brings out the concept of divine play. He gives the example of *Devadatta*, a person whose different body parts have an entity of their own but they work together as a unit i.e *Devadatta's* body and the self who keeps them all together is nothing but *Siva*.

Ishwar Pratibhijna Karika

PRATYABHIJNA MADE EASY.



ISHWAR PRATYABHIJNA KARIKA

Epilogue

Pratyabhijna defined

तैस्तैरप्युपयाचितैरुपनतस्तन्व्या
स्थितोप्यंतिके कांतोलोकसमान एवमपरिज्ञातो नरंतुं यथा
लोकस्यैषतथानवेक्षितगुणः स्वात्मापिविश्वेश्वरः
नैवालं निजवैभवायतदित्यंतत्प्रत्यभिज्ञोदिता ।

Even as the lover with whom the beloved is infatuated by hearing about his attributes ,is standing just near her ,is ignored and she remains indifferent . She has no carnal attraction towards him like for any other person in the world .

Shiva The universal self and thus the innermost self of an aspirant doesn't impart all of his grandeur and affluence unless identified as his essential nature . This is defined as pratyabhijna .

This definition of pratyabhijna is based on the legend of Nal and Damayanti . Damayanti has just learnt about the virtues and description of nala from a swan's word of mouth . But hasn't seen him directly . During her Swamvara (a wedding in which the bride chooses her groom out of many suitors) even while he is standing quite near her, till unrecognized he is just like any other suitor who have come to marry her. She has no amorous infatuation with him.

In the same manner the lord of the universe is the very self of all beings but until there is an intuitive insight into his being the immediate, universal and essential

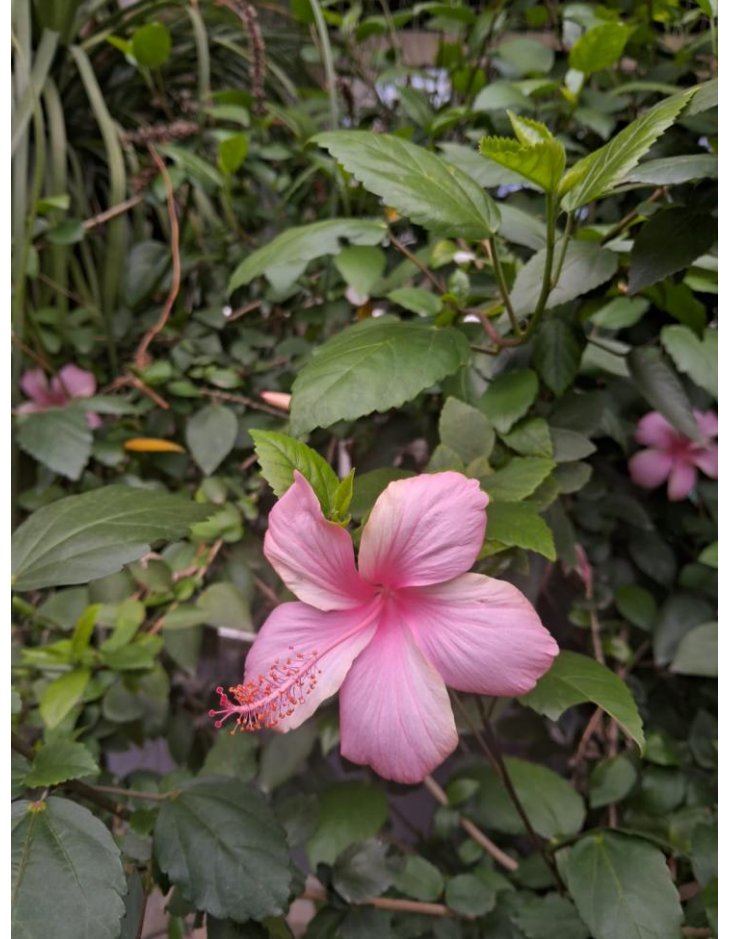
nature one does not imbibe his grandeur and magnanimity -this phenomenon is Termed as *pratyabhijna*.

तन्वी means

- 1 a slim girl
- 2 a girl weakened by penance and austerities to attain the man after her heart
- 3 none of the above

owing to the Oblivion of attributes the lord of the universe who is also the universal self

- 1 cannot liberate a soul
- 2 cannot make an aspirant like himself
- 3 cannot impart his lord ship and grandeur
- 4 2&3



A brief insight in the online classes conducted by YTA

In the Yogtantragama Study Circle we read and discuss many arcane texts in the divine guidance of our Guru Maharaj Swami Paranand Tirth ji. Swamiji reads and explains the metaphysical import of these texts along with conventional commentaries.

Currently we are studying Brahma Sutra Bhashya of Srikanthacharya with the commentary Shivarkamani Dipika by Appaya Dikshita and Shivdrsti of Somanandnath with a commentary Sivadrsti vrtti by Utpalacharya. While the former one is a Saivite insight into the Brahma Sutras, the latter is the first philosophical treatise on the monistic Saivism of Kashmir laying foundations of Pratyabhijna school of philosophy.

We have completed the study of Nityasodasikarnava with two commentaries Rjuvimarsini by Sivananda, and Artharatnavali by Vidyananda, Prapanchsara Tantra and Chidgaganchandrika. Though the classes are in sanskrit with a little patience and self study one can immensely benefit from them.



YTA Colloquium 2026: A Photo Essay



YTA Colloquium on Agama Shastra held on 9th April 2026 at Shri Lal Bahadur Shastri National Sanskrit University



Swami Paranand Tirth Maharaj, Founder President & CEO, YTA arriving at the location and lighting the ceremonial lamp



Starting the Event with the gracious presence of Swami Paranand Tirth Maharaj guests of honour and assembly of scholars and researchers



Felicitating the guest of honour, Padma Shri Professor Abhiraj Rajendra Mishra, Former Vice-Chancellor of Sampurnanand Sanskrit University, Varanasi and Professor Umakant Tripathi, Principle, Department of Sanskrit, Govt. Postgraduate college, Mahoba



Session in Progress



Swamiji's observations, closing remarks and suggestions for furthering the Agamic studies



Valedictory Session

Yellow Mustard Flower



~ Ambika Talwar

Simple enchanting mustard flowers blow in balmy breeze,
yellow buds of a worldwide spice I smell on my knees.
Many language lines claim this tiny enriching seed –
mustard, moutarde, sarson, rai, rajika is no weed.
Latin mustum from must simply grape juice – Imagine
mixed with ground rai births mustum ardens my mandolin.
Makes me whisper, wOw! Sinapi, senf, senap, sporos spreads
far and wide – with wings, she flies to lands and breads.
Home in Sanskrit, sarshapa rises at Himalaya's feet;
wild she grows and quiet, pretty, apolitical a rare feat.
Tiny she is, she flies from cooking pan suddenly too hot
into Kannada as sasive – Hindi sarson makes a fragrant pot.
So I learn, king is Raja from rajika and black rai's tenacity.
Faith of the mustard seed crosses all lands – O such audacity!

(Ambika Talwar is an India-born author, poet, wellness consultant, artist, and educator whose vision is to realize her sacred destiny and invite others to brilliance. She has authored *4 Stars and 25 Roses* (poems for her father) and *My Greece: Mirrors & Metamorphoses* about her travels through Greece in 2002.)





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swamiparanand@gmail.com

